

Did Someone Happen it, or Was it Happened? Evidence from Corpus Data and Acceptability Judgments of Passive Unaccusatives

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Abstract

This study investigates passivization errors with unaccusatives in L2 English, known as passive unaccusatives (e.g., **The apple was fallen from the table.*). Two competing accounts are considered: the verbal passivization account (VPA), which attributes passive unaccusatives to misanalysis of unaccusatives as lexical causatives, and the structural passivization account (SPA), which explains them as overgeneralization of passive morphosyntax (be + -en). The two accounts yield distinct predictions concerning passivized intransitives and lexically causativized intransitives. To test these predictions, both a corpus analysis and an acceptability judgment task were conducted. A corpus analysis of the NICT JLE Corpus (1,281 Japanese learners) revealed that passive unaccusatives were more frequent than their non-target lexical causative counterparts (e.g., **Brian fell the apple from the table.*) and passive unergatives (e.g., **Leslie was walked.*). An acceptability judgment task with 30 Japanese-speaking learners (TOEIC 550–745) likewise showed higher ratings for passive unaccusatives compared to lexical causative unaccusatives and passive unergatives. Taken together, these results support the SPA, suggesting that L2 learners do not causativize unaccusatives but instead overgeneralize NP-movement associated with passivization. The converging corpus and experimental evidence therefore reject the VPA and provide empirical support for the SPA in explaining non-target passivization in L2 grammar.

Keywords: passive unaccusative, unaccusativity, L2 English, second language acquisition

1. Introduction

In second language (L2) research, the acquisition of unaccusativity has long been a central topic of investigation. Numerous studies have demonstrated the unaccusative–unergative distinction in L2 interlanguage grammar by showing learners’ sensitivity to constructions associated with these two verb classes (see, e.g., Park & Lakshmanan, 2007; Fukuda, 2017; Hirakawa, 2001).

Among the many phenomena related to unaccusativity in L2 acquisition, passivization errors with unaccusative verbs—often referred to as *passive unaccusatives*—have attracted particular attention (e.g., Ju, 2000; Kim, Han, & Lee, 2025; Oshita, 2000, 2001; Tazaki, 2024b, c). L2 English learners frequently accept and produce non-target passive sentences with unaccusatives (e.g., **Brian was arrived*) but rarely with unergatives (see Oshita, 2000). Intriguingly, these errors are produced regardless of learners’ L1s (see Oshita, 2000, 2001). Since the initial discovery of these errors by Zobl (1989), research on passive unaccusatives has continued to flourish. Early work focused primarily on the contrast between the two classes of intransitives. Later studies identified additional factors influencing passive unaccusatives: Ju (2000) reported discourse-pragmatic effects, Yusa (2003) claimed event telicity effects, and Chung (2014) and Tazaki (2024b, c) documented effects of subject animacy and agentivity.

Despite extensive investigation, the origin of passive unaccusatives remains controversial.

The literature presents two main positions: (i) passivization of unaccusatives as verbal passivization (e.g., Ju, 2000; Yap, 1995), and (ii) passivization of unaccusatives as structural passivization (Oshita, 2000; Tazaki, 2025b). The former assumes that passive unaccusatives involve an implied causer of the event, whereas the latter does not (for details, see Section 2). Because of these differing assumptions, the same empirical observation is often given two competing explanations. For instance, Chung (2014) accounts for subject animacy effects under the verbal passivization approach, whereas Tazaki (2024b, c) analyzes them under the structural passivization approach.

Although many studies have documented the recurrence of passive unaccusatives in L2 English, relatively few have directly addressed the question of whether their source is verbal or structural. Exceptions include Oshita (2000) and Tazaki (2024b, c), both of which analyzed learner corpora and presented strong evidence for the structural passivization account. Nevertheless, many researchers continue to adopt the verbal passivization account without fully engaging with the issues raised by Oshita and Tazaki. Importantly, the choice between the two accounts fundamentally alters explanations of the observed effects on passive unaccusatives. Thus, it is essential for researchers to understand the theoretical assumptions, empirical predictions, and conceptual challenges of both accounts.

The present article seeks to disentangle these two approaches—the verbal passivization account and the structural passivization account—by testing their predictions through a corpus analysis and an acceptability judgment task. The results strongly support the structural passivization account, showing that passivization of unaccusatives reflects structural rather than verbal passivization. These findings suggest that all reported effects on passive unaccusatives must be explained without invoking verbal passivization.

2. Verbal Passivization Account vs. Structural Passivization Account

This section summarizes two competing assumptions regarding passive unaccusatives. The first assumes that passivization errors arise from verbal passivization, while the second attributes them to structural passivization, without contributing to meaning. I refer to these as *the verbal passivization account* (VPA) and *the structural passivization account* (SPA), respectively.

2.1 The Verbal Passivization Account (VPA)

One straightforward explanation for passivization errors is to analyze them as instances of verbal passivization with an implicit cause or causer (e.g., Chung, 2014; Ju, 2000; Yip, 1995). Under this verbal passivization account (VPA), passivization of unaccusatives involves two steps: (i) lexical causativization of unaccusatives, which adds an external argument to the argument structure of unaccusatives (i.e., ($__ <y>$) $\rightarrow$ ($x <y>$)), and (ii) passivization of lexically causativized, suppressing an external argument (i.e., ($x <y>$) $\rightarrow$ ($\% <y>$)). These two steps imply that unaccusatives are reanalyzed as lexical causatives in the interlanguage grammar of L2 English learners.

However, the VPA faces several empirical problems. First, it fails to account for the asymmetry in error rates: passive unaccusatives are far more common than passive unergatives. Because the VPA does not crucially depend on the unaccusative–unergative distinction, it cannot explain the scarcity of passive unergatives. Second, the assumption of causativization predicts that learners should also produce lexical causative errors (e.g., **Brian arrived Leslie at the library*, intended meaning: “Brian made Leslie arrive at the library”) in addition to passive errors. Yet, previous studies have shown that such causative errors are much rarer than passive errors, posing a serious challenge to the VPA (see Oshita, 2000; Tazaki, 2024b).

2.2 The Structural Passivization Account (SPA)

The structural passivization account (SPA) explains passivization phenomena within the generative framework. In this view, unergatives and unaccusatives have distinct structural representations: unergatives have an external argument, base-generated outside of the VP, while unaccusatives have an internal argument, base-generated inside of the VP, which subsequently moves to subject position (Spec-TP). This distinction is illustrated in (1).

- (1) a. [TP Leslie [VP walked]] (unergative)
b. [TP Leslie [VP arrived *t*]] (unaccusative)

The derivation of unaccusatives is similar to that of passives in that both involve movement of an internal argument NP from the complement position of the verb to Spec-TP. The SPA argues that learners are misled by this structural similarity: they associate NP-movement with the passive morphosyntax *be + en* and overgeneralize it to unaccusatives (e.g., Oshita, 2000, 2001, 2022; Tazaki, 2024b, 2024c, 2025a, 2025b; Tazaki & Hattori, 2025).

According to this account, learners who are not sensitive to the unaccusative–unergative distinction should not produce passivization errors with unaccusatives (see Oshita, 2001, 2014). Oshita argues that L2 learners are initially insensitive to this distinction due to the similarity of their surface word order (Subject–Verb).¹ At this early stage, learners are not expected to produce passive unaccusatives.²

Unlike the VPA, the SPA does not predict causativization in passive unaccusatives, and it successfully accounts for the difference in error rates: passive unaccusatives are attested, while passive unergatives are rare, since unergatives do not involve NP-movement.³

3. Predictions

The two accounts make distinct predictions regarding passive and lexical causative errors. The VPA predicts that L2 English learners will accept and produce lexically causativized unaccusatives and passivized unergatives in addition to passivized unaccusatives. In contrast, the SPA does not necessarily predict lexical causative errors, but it does predict that passivization errors will occur more frequently with unaccusatives than with unergatives. These predictions are summarized below (“A > B” indicates that A is expected to occur more frequently than B).

- (2) *Predictions of the VPA*
a. passive unaccusative = passive unergative
b. passive unaccusative = causative unaccusative

¹ This hypothesis requires further investigation before it can be fully accepted, as some research suggests that L2 learners are capable of distinguishing unaccusatives from unergatives from the very beginning (e.g., Kimura & Hirokawa, 2025).

² The statement “Learners are not expected to produce passive unaccusatives” does not mean that learners never produce passive errors, but rather that the proportion of passive unaccusatives is expected to be comparable to that of passive unergatives. See Oshita (2014) for detailed discussion.

³ If the VP-internal subject hypothesis is adopted, unergatives also involve NP-movement. Based on this assumption, Yusa (2003) argues against the VPA. However, even if the external argument of unergatives moves from Spec-VP to Spec-TP, this differs from passives and unaccusatives in that it does not cross the predicate. Moreover, NP-movement in unergatives involves an external argument, whereas in unaccusatives and passives it involves an internal argument. Crucially, what matters for the SPA is that NP-movement in unaccusatives—but not in unergatives—closely resembles that in passives. Hence, Yusa’s argument does not undermine the SPA.

- (3) *Predictions of the SPA*⁴
- a. passive unaccusative > passive unergative
 - b. passive unaccusative > causative unaccusative

4. A Corpus Analysis

4.1 Learner Corpus

To evaluate the predictions made by the VPA and the SPA, we first conducted a corpus analysis using the NICT JLE Corpus (National Institute of Information and Communications Technology, 2003), a large-scale learner corpus consisting of spoken data from 1,281 Japanese-speaking learners of English. While several previous studies have examined passive unaccusatives using learner corpora, most of them analyzed written production rather than spoken production (e.g., Oshita, 2000; Tazaki, 2024b, 2024c). If passive unaccusatives are also attested in spoken data, this would further confirm the prevalence of passivization errors with unaccusatives.

4.2 Methods

Following previous studies (Oshita, 2000; Tazaki, 2024a), 10 unaccusatives and 10 unergatives were preselected. All verbs are non-alternating verbs, meaning that they cannot be used in causative constructions. The target verbs are listed in (4).

- (4) a. Unaccusative:
arrive, fall, appear, disappear, happen, occur, exist, remain, die, stay
- b. Unergatives:
swim, walk, jump, dance, smile, shout, talk, sleep, laugh, cry

For the analysis, bare, past, and past participle forms were included (e.g., *fall(s), fell, fallen*), but the *-ing* form (e.g., *arriving*) was excluded. Target tokens were categorized into three structures: grammatical active (NP-V), ungrammatical passive (NP-*be*-V(*en*)), and ungrammatical lexical causative (NP₁-V-NP₂). Tokens outside these categories were excluded (e.g., unexpressed subjects: *___ arrived at the school.*). Raising verbs (e.g., *Miki happened to see her friend*) and verbs in non-finite clauses (e.g., infinitives, participle constructions) were also excluded, as they involve different complement structures or lack overt argument positions. In addition, transitive uses of target verbs without causative meaning (e.g., *Leslie arrived ___ the park. Cf. Leslie arrived at the park*) were classified as active rather than causative.

4.3 Results

In the NICT JLE Corpus, 902 unaccusative and 971 unergative sentences were identified across the three target structures. Table 1 presents the overall syntactic distribution.

Table 1. The Number of Extracted Verbs

Verb Type	NP-V	NP- <i>be</i> -V(<i>en</i>)	NP ₁ -V-NP ₂	Total
Unaccusative	852 (94.5%)	47 (5.2%)	3 (0.3%)	902 (100%)
Unergative	946 (97.4%)	24 (2.5%)	1 (0.1%)	971 (100%)

⁴ Strictly speaking, the SPA does not predict “passive unaccusatives > causative unaccusatives,” since nothing in this account prevents unaccusatives from being overcausativized. However, because the emergence of overcausativization would support the VPA, prediction (3b) can be regarded as a desirable consequence for the SPA to be fully accepted.

As Table 1 shows, unaccusatives and unergatives appear in the passive structure at rates of 47/902 (5.2%) and 24/971 (2.5%), respectively. Although overall error rates are low compared to the majority of correct active sentences (unaccusatives: 852/902 = 94.5%; unergatives: 946/971 = 97.4%), the difference between unaccusatives and unergatives is statistically significant ($\chi^2(1) = 8.88, p = .0029$). This suggests that learners are more prone to passivize unaccusatives than unergatives. Compared to lexical causativization, passive unaccusatives occurred much more frequently: 47/902 unaccusatives were passivized, whereas only 3 (0.3%) were causativized. Examples of passive unaccusatives and passive unergatives are given in (5) and (6).⁵

- (5) a. *...that shape are appeared... [file00886]
b. *...my bag wasn't arrived yet. [file00353]
c. *...where I'm stayed... [file00192]
d. *...the case of murder is occurred. [file00559]
- (6) a. *When I was walked down a street... [file00701]
b. *...we are talk about my family. [file00050]
c. *...if we meet at the first time we are smile... [file00014]
d. *...before my son is not shout but... [file00245]

The analysis so far treated *be* + *bare form* (e.g., *be arrive*) as passive. However, this type of error might instead reflect overgeneralization of the copular *be* (see Otaki, 2023; Wakabayashi, 2021). Such errors occur across verb types and typically involve uninflected lexical verbs (Wakabayashi, 2021). To distinguish between true passivization errors and *be*-insertion errors, we further subdivided passive tokens into NP-*be*-Ven and NP-*be*-V. The latter category included past-form verbs such as *fell*. Table 2 summarizes the results.

Table 2. NP-*be*-Ven vs. NP-*be*-V

Verb Type	NP-V	NP- <i>be</i> -Ven	NP- <i>be</i> -V	NP ₁ -V-NP ₂	Total
Unaccusative	852 (94.5)	28 (3.1)	19 (2.1)	3 (0.3)	902 (100)
Unergative	946 (97.4)	3 (0.3)	21 (2.2)	1 (0.1)	971 (100)

Note. The number in parenthesis indicates percentage

For clarity, we refer to NP-*be*-Ven as “true” passives and NP-*be*-V as “pseudo” passives. As Table 2 shows, true passives patterned as before: unaccusatives were more likely than unergatives to be passivized (3.1% vs. 0.3%), and the difference was statistically significant ($\chi^2(1) = 20.76, p < .0001$). Passive unaccusatives also occurred significantly more frequently than causative unaccusatives.

By contrast, pseudo passives did not differ between unaccusatives and unergatives ($\chi^2(1) < 0.01, p = 1.0$), suggesting that they should be analyzed as copula *be*-overgeneralization rather than passivization errors (Otaki, 2023; Wakabayashi, 2021). Crucially, an analysis of true passive intransitives reveals that passive unergatives are exceedingly rare.

Taken together, these findings show that unaccusatives are significantly more prone to

⁵ Since the data are derived from spoken production, they contain fillers (e.g., *umm*) and repetitions of the same words. These were omitted in the examples in (5) and (6).

passivization than unergatives, and passive unaccusatives occur more frequently than causative unaccusatives. These results clearly support the SPA, while posing challenges for the VPA.

5. An Acceptability Judgment Task

5.1 Participants

30 Japanese-speaking learners of English were recruited via Lancers, a Japanese crowdsourcing service (<https://hosting.lancers.jp/lp/client/>). Only individuals who had taken the TOEIC test within the past year and whose scores ranged between 550 and 780 (CEFR: B1) were invited to participate. This range was selected because previous studies using TOEIC as a proficiency measure showed that learners with scores in this band exhibit sensitivity to the unaccusative–unergative distinction (see Tazaki, 2024a; Tazaki & Hattori, 2025). Such sensitivity is crucial, as the SPA does not predict differences between unaccusatives and unergatives if learners are insensitive to this distinction. Prior to the experiment, participants self-reported their TOEIC scores and the dates they obtained them. Four of the 30 participants did not meet the criteria and were excluded. The final analysis therefore included 26 participants.

5.2 Materials and Procedure

An acceptability judgment task was designed, which follows a 2×2 factorial design, manipulating verb type (unaccusative vs. unergative) and structure type (NP-*be*-Ven vs. NP₁-V-NP₂). For the experiment, four unaccusatives (*die*, *appear*, *disappear*, *fall*) and four unergatives (*walk*, *dance*, *sing*, *study*) were selected. Each verb was presented in either a passive construction (i.e., NP-*be*-Ven) or a causative construction (i.e., NP₁-V-NP₂), as illustrated in (7). Each sentence was accompanied by a contextual paragraph written in participants' L1 Japanese. The contextual paragraphs appearing with passive sentences do not introduce any potential causers to the event denoted by the intransitive verbs, so that the interpretation that comes from verbal passivization is difficult to obtain.

- (7) a. The big apple was fallen from the table. (passive)
b. Bruce fell the expensive cup from the table. (causative)

The subjects of passive unergatives were always animate (agentive), whereas those of passive unaccusatives were inanimate (non-agentive). Inanimate subjects were chosen because, as argued by Tazaki (2024b, 2024c, 2025a) and Tazaki & Hattori (2025), unaccusatives with animate, agentive subjects are often reanalyzed as unergatives in L2 interlanguage.

To minimize lexical repetition effects, target sentences were distributed across two lists. Each list contained the eight target verbs, each presented once in either the passive or causative frame. Sixteen filler sentences were added, resulting in 24 test sentences per list, plus three practice trials. Sentences were pseudorandomized. Participants rated each sentence on a 7-point scale, from 1 (*incorrect*) to 7 (*correct*).

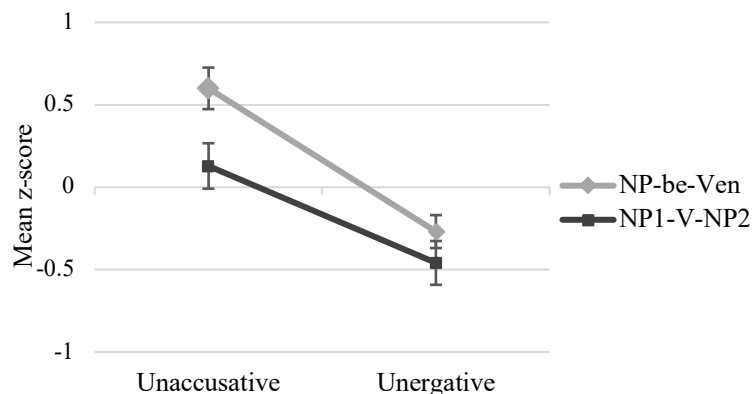
5.3 Results

The raw data was converted into z-score to standardize the rating. A linear mixed effects model was fitted with VERB TYPE (unaccusative vs. unergative) and STRUCTURE (passive vs. causative) as fixed effects and Participant and Item as random effects. Table 3 and Figure 1 present the mean row scores and a visualization of z-score, respectively

Table 3. The Mean Scores and Standard Deviations

Verb Type	NP- <i>be</i> -Ven	NP ₁ -V-NP ₂
Unaccusative	4.56 (2.08)	3.59 (1.89)
Unergative	2.78 (2.00)	2.39 (1.51)

Figure 1. Mean Z-scores and Error Bars



Since all target verbs were non-alternating intransitives, both the passive and causative constructions were ungrammatical. Thus, if learners possessed target-like knowledge, all target sentences should have been rejected. However, as shown in Figure 1, this was not the case. Unaccusatives were generally accepted more often than unergatives, and passive sentences were rated more highly than causative sentences.

A linear mixed effect model revealed significant main effects of VERB TYPE ($\beta = -0.549$, $SE = 0.180$, $t(12.67) = -3.043$, $p = .0097$), and STRUCTURE ($\beta = 0.528$, $SE = 0.156$, $t(178.46) = 3.388$, $p < .001$). The interaction between VERB TYPE and STRUCTURE was not statistically significant ($\beta = -0.360$, $SE = 0.220$, $t(178.46) = -1.633$, $p = .104$).

Post hoc pairwise comparisons revealed that unaccusative verbs received significantly higher acceptability ratings than unergative verbs in both the causative context ($estimate = 0.549$, $p = .0096$) and the passive context ($p = .0002$). Additionally, within unaccusative verbs, passive forms were rated significantly higher than causative forms ($p = .0011$), whereas for unergative verbs, the difference between passive and causative structures was not significant ($p = .2924$). The summarized pairwise comparisons were displayed in Table 4.

Table 4. Pairwise Comparisons of Conditions

Comparison	Estimate	SE	df	t	p
UA vs UE (Caus.)	0.549	0.182	13.4	3.018	.0096
UA vs UE (Pass.)	0.909	0.182	13.4	4.996	.0002
Caus. vs Pass. (UA)	-0.528	0.159	179	-3.315	.0011
Caus. vs Pass. (UE)	-0.168	0.159	179	-1.056	.2924

Note. UA = unaccusative, UE = unergative, Caus. = NP₁-V-NP₂, Pass. = NP-*be*-Ven

In sum, learners rated passive unaccusatives more highly than both passive unergatives and causative unaccusatives. These results support the SPA while posing problems for the VPA.

6. Discussion

Both the corpus analysis and the acceptability judgment task yielded a similar pattern: passive unaccusatives occurred more frequently than passive unergatives and causative unaccusatives. Our primary objective was to determine which account—the VPA or the SPA—provides a more plausible explanation of passive unaccusatives. The VPA attributes passivization to non-target causativization, whereas the SPA attributes it to learners' strong association of NP-movement with passive morphosyntax. Because of these distinct assumptions, the two accounts make different predictions, repeated in (8) and (9).

(8) *Predictions of the VPA* (= 2)

- a. passive unaccusative = passive unergative
- b. passive unaccusative = causative unaccusative

(9) *Predictions of the SPA* (= 3)

- a. passive unaccusative > passive unergative
- b. passive unaccusative > causative unaccusative

The VPA predicts that all conditions should be equally accepted and produced, whereas the SPA predicts that passive unaccusatives will be accepted and produced more frequently than passive unergatives and causative unaccusatives (see also footnote 4). The findings from both the corpus analysis and the acceptability judgment task align with the predictions of the SPA, demonstrating that the SPA provides the more plausible explanation: L2 learners overgeneralize passive morphosyntax to the NP-movement required in unaccusative constructions.

These findings are expected to have significant implications for the theoretical treatment of passive unaccusatives. As noted at the outset of this paper, many previous studies have reported effects on passive unaccusatives—such as subject animacy and agentivity, discourse-pragmatic factors, and event telicity. Explanations of these effects differ depending on whether the VPA or the SPA is assumed. The present study, together with previous work (e.g., Oshita, 2000; Tazaki, 2024b; Tazaki & Hattori, 2025), demonstrates that the SPA is the more plausible account, thereby calling for a rejection or revision of theories developed on the basis of the VPA. By contrast, explanations grounded in the SPA appear to be on the right track toward a comprehensive account that can unify the observed effects (see Tazaki, 2025b, for a novel hypothesis extending the SPA to explain these effects).

Before concluding this paper, we would like to think about the question of why passivization of unaccusatives occurs in the acquisition of L2 English but not in the acquisition of L1 English. Despite the prevalence of passive unaccusatives in L2 English, such errors have not been reported in L1 English. One possible explanation for this L1–L2 asymmetry lies in differences between L1 and L2 acquisition mechanisms. Unlike L1 acquisition, L2 acquisition is known to be strongly influenced by linear sequences (see Kimura, in press; Oshita, 2001). Regarding unaccusativity, Oshita (2001) argues that L2 learners initially analyze all intransitives as unergatives with only an external argument, due to the predominant NP–V word order in the input. Awareness of unaccusative verbs with an internal argument emerges only later in the developmental sequence. By contrast, L2 learners acquire passivization relatively early. Thus, at the initial stage of interlanguage, the only derivation involving NP-movement is the passive construction. Once learners begin to recognize the two distinct classes of intransitives, they struggle with unaccusatives, which require NP-movement of the internal argument. At this stage, they may fail to accept grammatical unaccusative sentences in NP–V order and instead accept ungrammatical passivized unaccusatives (see Oshita, 2000, 2002, 2004, 2014). In other

words, learners sometimes resort to passivization as a strategy to handle NP-movement in unaccusatives.

In contrast, L1 English learners do not passivize unaccusatives. Their successful acquisition of unaccusativity may be related to the acquisition order of unaccusativity and passivization. Cross-linguistic research shows that children acquire unaccusativity relatively easily (see Becker & Schaeffer, 2013; Shimada & Sano, 2007; Wang et al., 2024), but struggle with passives (see Deen, 2011). Although the reason why unaccusativity is acquired earlier than passives in L1 remains unclear, this acquisition order may account for the L1–L2 asymmetry. In L1, learners first acquire unaccusatives with morphologically covert NP-movement, so when they later acquire passives, passive morphosyntax is not overgeneralized to unaccusative derivations. In contrast, in L2 English, learners acquire passives before unaccusatives; thus, when unaccusativity is later acquired, learners overgeneralize morphologically overt NP-movement from passives to unaccusative derivations.

If this explanation is correct, an important question is whether L1 English children ever overgeneralize the morphologically covert NP-movement of unaccusatives to passives. While this question is beyond the scope of the present study, it is an important issue for future research.

7. Conclusion

This study examined two competing accounts of passive unaccusatives—the VPA and the SPA—by analyzing both corpus data and acceptability judgments. The two accounts yield distinct predictions, enabling empirical testing. The results provided robust evidence that passivization of unaccusatives reflects structural passivization, without semantic contribution, rather than verbal passivization.

One advantage of the VPA has been its ability to explain effects of discourse–pragmatics (Ju, 2000) and subject animacy (Chung, 2014) on passive unaccusatives. However, Tazaki (2025b) has recently proposed a new hypothesis that explains these effects under the assumptions of the SPA, suggesting that a connection between passivization and causativization need not be assumed.

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